

# Difficult Vocabulary

Paper 1 — Comprehension (Text A)

9 Past Papers | Specimen • 2024 • 2025

A revision reference for Cambridge O Level English Language (1123).  
Every word is extracted directly from the Text A passage, with a simple meaning, an example sentence, and easier synonyms.

## How to use this pack

1. Read each word in the context of its example sentence.
2. Memorise at least one *simpler* synonym — these are the words the mark scheme rewards in Q1 vocabulary questions.
3. Re-read the full Text A passage afterwards — you'll catch the words in their original setting.

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## Specimen — Nameless

**1. incredulously** — in a way that shows disbelief

*"Marwood stared at him incredulously when he heard the plan."*

**Synonyms:** doubtfully, unbelievably, disbelievingly

**2. fluid** — smooth and flowing (as a movement)

*"He swung himself up in one fluid movement."*

**Synonyms:** smooth, flowing, graceful

**3. relentless** — never stopping or slowing

*"Hit by light, the redwood grows with relentless speed."*

**Synonyms:** non-stop, endless, unstoppable

**4. basked** — enjoyed warmth or light

*"Nameless had basked in sunlight for centuries."*

**Synonyms:** soaked up, enjoyed, lay in

**5. precarious** — unsafe and likely to fall

*"He climbed the next precarious metres up the trunk."*

**Synonyms:** risky, unsafe, shaky

**6. labyrinth** — a complicated maze-like space

*"Mo climbed slowly through the labyrinth of branches."*

**Synonyms:** maze, tangle, network

**7. foliage** — the leaves of trees and plants

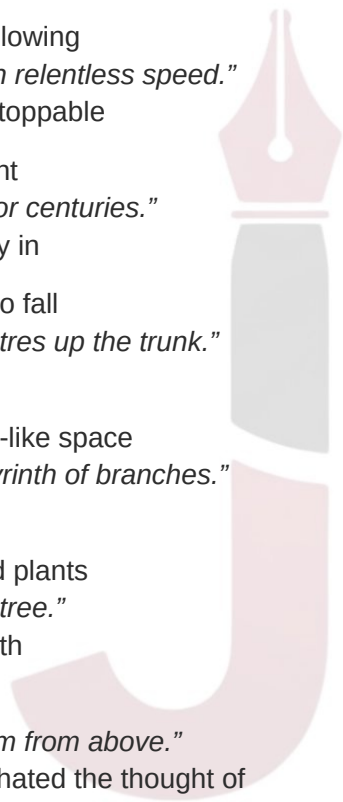
*"Clouds of foliage hid the top of the tree."*

**Synonyms:** leaves, greenery, growth

**8. dreaded** — feared greatly

*"Marwood dreaded hearing a scream from above."*

**Synonyms:** feared, worried about, hated the thought of



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## S24 / 11 — The North Shore

1. **despairingly** — without any hope

*"He paddled despairingly against the fierce wind."*

**Synonyms:** hopelessly, sadly, miserably

2. **inhospitable** — harsh and unwelcoming

*"The inhospitable coast offered no shelter."*

**Synonyms:** harsh, unfriendly, bleak

3. **battered** — damaged by repeated blows

*"His battered canoe was almost paper-thin."*

**Synonyms:** bruised, beaten, worn

4. **respite** — a short break from something hard

*"The dawn brought no respite from the storm."*

**Synonyms:** break, rest, pause

5. **dismal** — gloomy and depressing

*"The skies were grey and dismal all morning."*

**Synonyms:** gloomy, bleak, dreary

6. **frigid** — extremely cold

*"The frigid gusts cut straight through his jacket."*

**Synonyms:** freezing, icy, bitter

7. **desolate** — empty and lonely

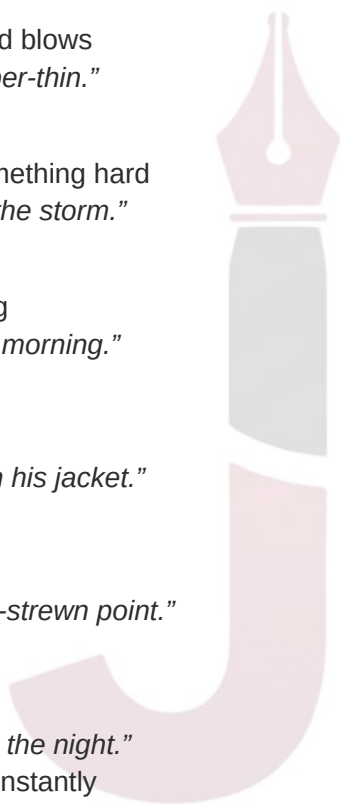
*"He was trapped on a desolate rock-strewn point."*

**Synonyms:** empty, lonely, bare

8. **ceaselessly** — without stopping

*"The wind blew ceaselessly through the night."*

**Synonyms:** endlessly, non-stop, constantly



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## S24 / 12 — The Ice

**1. enchanted** — charmed or delighted

*"The child was enchanted by the glowing ice shards."*

**Synonyms:** charmed, delighted, spellbound

**2. stifling** — so hot it's hard to breathe

*"The stifling kitchen made him sweat within seconds."*

**Synonyms:** suffocating, boiling, airless

**3. warranted** — deserved or justified

*"His punishment was warranted after the careless mistake."*

**Synonyms:** deserved, fair, justified

**4. searing** — painfully burning

*"The searing cold felt like fire against his skin."*

**Synonyms:** burning, scorching, stinging

**5. feebly** — very weakly

*"He leaned feebly against the door, barely able to stand."*

**Synonyms:** weakly, faintly, limply

**6. taunting** — teasing someone cruelly

*"Ahmad's taunting tone made the boy feel small."*

**Synonyms:** mocking, teasing, needling

**7. alchemist** — an old-style magical chemist

*"He worked in the kitchen like a young alchemist."*

**Synonyms:** chemist, mixer, wizard

**8. outlandish** — strange and unusual

*"He tried the most outlandish flavour combinations."*

**Synonyms:** strange, bizarre, odd

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## S25 / 11 — Our Family Restaurant

**1. slathered** — thickly spread or covered

*"The bread was slathered with butter."*

**Synonyms:** smeared, covered, layered

**2. repertoire** — a collection of things someone can do

*"Her repertoire of dishes grew every year."*

**Synonyms:** collection, range, list

**3. notorious** — famous for bad reasons

*"The notorious shanty town lay just beyond the wall."*

**Synonyms:** infamous, ill-famed, well-known

**4. affluent** — rich

*"The affluent neighbourhood had tall glass buildings."*

**Synonyms:** rich, wealthy, well-off

**5. reverberated** — echoed loudly

*"Laughter reverberated across the dance floor."*

**Synonyms:** echoed, boomed, rang

**6. waddled** — walked clumsily, like a duck

*"The plump man waddled between the tables."*

**Synonyms:** swayed, rolled, shuffled

**7. scrutinised** — examined very closely

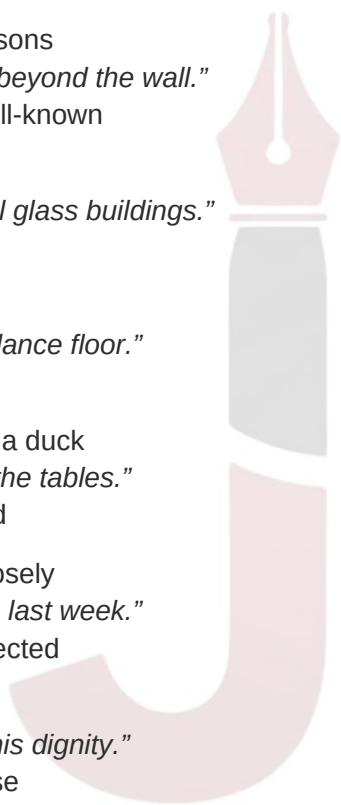
*"They scrutinised every receipt from last week."*

**Synonyms:** studied, checked, inspected

**8. dignity** — self-respect

*"Bappu adjusted his hat, regaining his dignity."*

**Synonyms:** self-respect, pride, poise



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## S25 / 12 — Jahan and Chota

**1. intently** — with focused attention

*"Jahan peered intently ahead at the distant shore."*

**Synonyms:** closely, carefully, firmly

**2. downcast** — very sad and low

*"Chota looked downcast and listless in the crate."*

**Synonyms:** sad, gloomy, miserable

**3. endured** — suffered through something hard

*"Nothing could be worse than the voyage they had endured."*

**Synonyms:** survived, bore, got through

**4. disdain** — a look of scorn or dislike

*"The sailors eyed the elephant with disdain."*

**Synonyms:** scorn, contempt, dislike

**5. levitated** — rose as if floating

*"The crate levitated bit by bit as the ropes tightened."*

**Synonyms:** floated, lifted, rose

**6. scampered** — ran with small, quick steps

*"Jahan scampered back and forth, helping where he could."*

**Synonyms:** dashed, scurried, hurried

**7. lofty** — very tall and high

*"The barn had a lofty ceiling and earthen floor."*

**Synonyms:** tall, high, towering

**8. resplendent** — dazzlingly beautiful

*"Chota looked resplendent in his golden saddlecloth."*

**Synonyms:** dazzling, magnificent, stunning

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## W24 / 11 — World's Oldest Swim

**1. interrogated** — questioned intensely

*"Ed interrogated us about our swim preparations."*

**Synonyms:** questioned, grilled, quizzed

**2. pessimistic** — expecting the worst

*"His pessimistic remarks ruined the group's mood."*

**Synonyms:** gloomy, negative, hopeless

**3. solemnly** — very seriously

*"The group marched solemnly towards the ferry."*

**Synonyms:** seriously, gravely, quietly

**4. recklessly** — dangerously and without care

*"He dived recklessly into the crowd of swimmers."*

**Synonyms:** carelessly, wildly, rashly

**5. squirming** — twisting and wriggling

*"A squirming mass of swimmers filled the water."*

**Synonyms:** wriggling, twisting, writhing

**6. shimmering** — sparkling softly with light

*"Shimmering fish darted beneath the surface."*

**Synonyms:** sparkling, glinting, shining

**7. disembarked** — got off (a boat or vehicle)

*"We disembarked and queued at the starting line."*

**Synonyms:** got off, unloaded, landed

**8. flustered** — stressed and confused

*"He rejoined the queue, flustered and apologetic."*

**Synonyms:** flurried, ruffled, panicked

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## W24 / 12 — The Puma

1. **rickety** — unsteady and old

*"The rickety bus jolted down the jungle road."*

**Synonyms:** shaky, unsteady, wobbly

2. **reluctantly** — not wanting to

*"She reluctantly lifted the child off her lap."*

**Synonyms:** unwillingly, hesitantly, grudgingly

3. **looming** — appearing large and threatening

*"The jungle rose around her, looming and silent."*

**Synonyms:** towering, rising, overhanging

4. **clasped** — held very tightly

*"The boar had a red sock clasped in its teeth."*

**Synonyms:** gripped, held, clutched

5. **dazed** — stunned and unable to think clearly

*"She stood dazed at the word 'puma'."*

**Synonyms:** stunned, shaken, bewildered

6. **transfixed** — frozen in fascination or fear

*"Laura stood transfixed by Wayra's bristling tail."*

**Synonyms:** frozen, rooted, glued

7. **bristling** — standing up stiffly

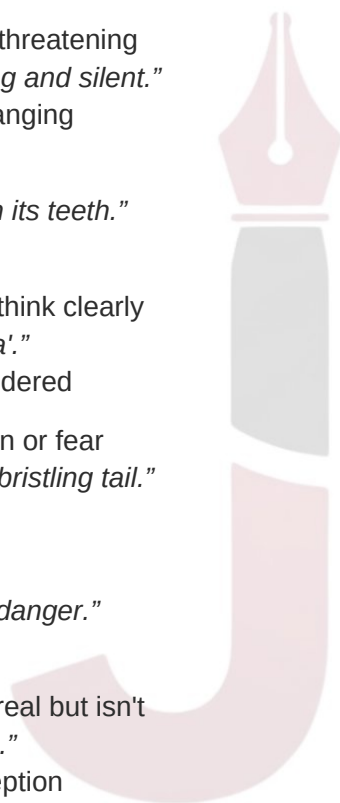
*"The puma's bristling fur warned of danger."*

**Synonyms:** stiff, raised, pricking

8. **illusion** — something that looks real but isn't

*"Her small size had been an illusion."*

**Synonyms:** false image, trick, deception



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## W25 / 11 — The Circus Train

1. **billowing** — rolling outward in large waves

*"Clouds of billowing smoke hid the horizon."*

**Synonyms:** rolling, swelling, puffing

2. **stupor** — a dazed, almost unconscious state

*"I snapped out of my stupor when I heard the whistle."*

**Synonyms:** daze, trance, haze

3. **lunge** — move forward suddenly

*"I had to lunge at the iron bar to pull myself in."*

**Synonyms:** leap, spring, dart

4. **theatrically** — in an exaggerated, dramatic way

*"Uncle Al stepped theatrically into the lantern light."*

**Synonyms:** dramatically, showily, grandly

5. **mockery** — scorn or cruel making fun

*"His eyes gleamed with mockery at the college boy."*

**Synonyms:** scorn, ridicule, teasing

6. **translucent** — letting some light through but not clear

*"The canvas tent was nearly translucent in the sun."*

**Synonyms:** see-through, cloudy-clear, light-letting

7. **gargantuan** — huge

*"The gargantuan elephant filled the side of the tent."*

**Synonyms:** huge, massive, giant

8. **mottled** — marked with spots of different colours

*"Her mottled skin looked like a cracked riverbed."*

**Synonyms:** spotted, blotchy, patchy

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## W25 / 12 — The Raven

**1. mischievous** — naughty in a playful way

*"Young ravens can be surprisingly mischievous."*

**Synonyms:** naughty, cheeky, playful

**2. captivity** — being kept in a cage

*"Birds raised in captivity struggle to survive outside."*

**Synonyms:** being caged, imprisonment, confinement

**3. petrified** — frozen with extreme fear

*"Odin gave a petrified croak and ran for the barn."*

**Synonyms:** terrified, shocked, frozen

**4. disconcerting** — making someone feel uneasy

*"His sudden landings could be disconcerting to guests."*

**Synonyms:** unsettling, unnerving, upsetting

**5. mayhem** — wild chaos and disorder

*"He revelled in the mayhem he caused at the play area."*

**Synonyms:** chaos, uproar, disorder

**6. delinquent** — badly behaved

*"Rex cemented blocks around the delinquent bird's cage."*

**Synonyms:** naughty, misbehaving, unruly

**7. wistfully** — with sad longing

*"He spoke wistfully about the bird they had lost."*

**Synonyms:** sadly, longingly, dreamily

**8. bedraggled** — wet, untidy and pitiful

*"A bedraggled Odin shivered at the top of the tree."*

**Synonyms:** soggy, messy, scruffy

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